

**Faithful
Foundations**

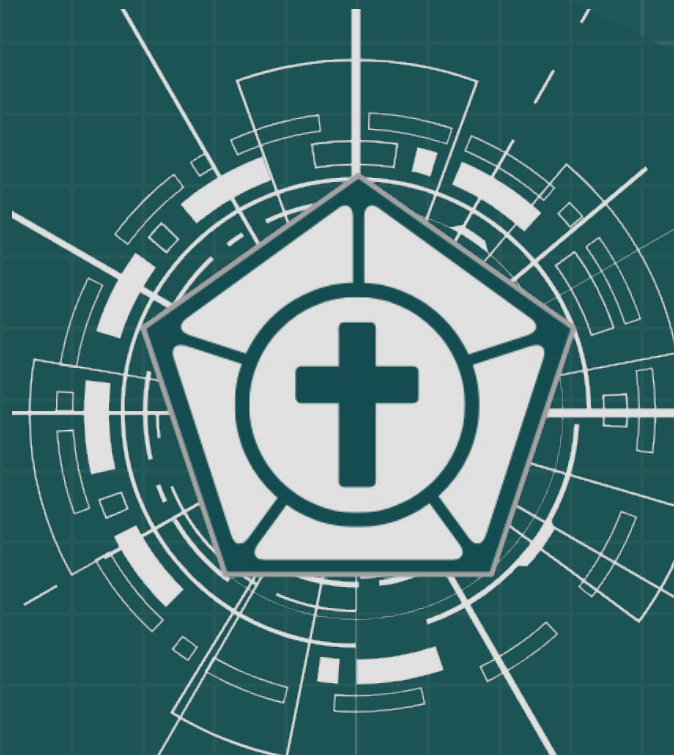
**Future-Ready
Formation**

Catholic Companion Framework

For Technology and Innovation

**Faithful Guidance
for Catholic Educators
Navigating Technology,
Artificial Intelligence,
& Innovation**

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First Edition.

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Welcome

About the Catholic Companion Framework

The Catholic Companion Framework for Technology and Innovation was written to help Catholic educators, leaders, and families navigate the opportunities and challenges of technology, artificial intelligence (AI), and innovation through the light of faith. Rooted in Church teaching and the wisdom of Catholic Social Thought, it offers a clear structure of anchor strands, substrands, and instructional goals that strengthen classroom instruction, guide decision-making, and support faith formation in a digital age.

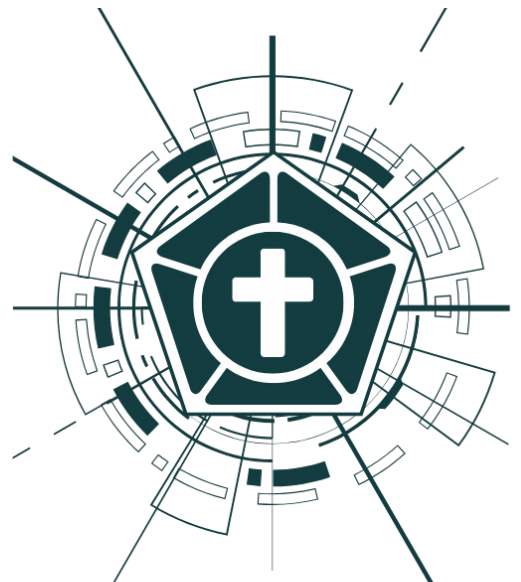
In this framework, technology refers to the digital tools, platforms, and systems that shape daily life; artificial intelligence to emerging forms of machine learning, virtual and augmented reality, and automation; and innovation to the creative and analytical human processes of developing and applying these tools. Together, these forces continue to transform the ways students learn, think, and live, making it ever more urgent that Catholic education form both hearts and minds for faithful engagement with present and future technologies.

Developed through reflection, research, and dialogue with educators and leaders in Catholic schools and parishes, the framework is informed by the lived experiences of those who teach and form students every day. It builds upon public efforts in digital and AI literacy while extending them into the moral, spiritual, and human dimensions that are essential to Catholic education.

Drawing on Catholic Social Teaching, the Catechism of the Catholic Church, papal reflections on technology and communication, and contemporary educational research, the Catholic Companion Framework seeks to ensure that the dignity of the human person remains at the heart of innovation.

As a First Edition, this framework is meant to grow and evolve. It marks the initial step in an ongoing effort to help Catholic educators, schools, and students think faithfully and act wisely amid technological change. As the Church's understanding of these issues continues to deepen and technology advances, future editions will incorporate new insights, applications, and voices from the field.

Above all, this framework is an invitation to reflect, to engage, and to act. May it spark meaningful conversations in classrooms, schools, homes, and parishes, giving Catholic educators in every role clarity and confidence to ensure that technology and innovation always serve the flourishing of students as children of God, created in His image.



The Urgency of the Moment

Technology is advancing faster than most schools, families, and institutions can adapt. New tools appear daily, promising efficiency, personalization, and connection, yet they also amplify the potential for distraction, disinformation, and dependence. The pace of innovation has outstripped our ability to respond thoughtfully. Teachers and parents alike are discerning how to guide students in digital spaces that shape their relationships, values, and imagination long before they reach adulthood. The need for thoughtful formation has never been more immediate.

This moment is filled with both wonder and worry. For some, the creativity and possibility of new tools and technologies spark hope for deeper learning, inclusion, and personalization. For others, the rapid pace of change brings fatigue, uncertainty, and fear of losing what makes education deeply human. Both responses are real and reasonable, and they point to the same truth: technology is not going away. It is here, transforming every aspect of how we live, learn, and relate to one another.



Artificial intelligence (AI) stands most recently at the center of this transformation. It is not simply another classroom tool or convenience at home, rather it is changing how knowledge itself is created, shared, and valued. Its reach across every subject, profession, and part of daily life challenges Catholic educators across spaces to ask not only what students should learn about technology, but who they are becoming because of it.

The challenge and the opportunity lie in the same place. Innovation can open extraordinary possibilities for creativity, collaboration, personalization, and even evangelization, but its impact depends on the intentions of those who design it and the choices of those who use it. Technology is not inherently good or bad. It takes on the character of the values and virtues that guide it.

For Catholic education, the question is not whether these tools will shape our students, but how we will guide that influence, ensuring that technology is oriented toward wisdom, responsibility, and faith rather than left to the values of the marketplace alone.

How can Catholic educators prepare students not only to navigate technology, but to live faithfully and wisely within a world shaped by it?

This framework was created to help Catholic educators meet that challenge with clarity, hope, and faith. It offers pathways for teaching, reflection, and formation that keep human dignity and moral discernment at the center of digital life. Its purpose is not to prescribe policies, promote specific technologies, or replace the ongoing work of Catholic formation, but to serve as a companion that supports it. It exists to help Catholic educators form young people capable of wisdom, creativity, and virtue in a rapidly changing world.

The Importance of Digital Literacy And Catholic Formation

Students are not waiting for adults to figure this out. They already live in a digital world, shaped by tools and platforms that influence their daily lives. From social media and streaming content to online games and emerging AI, technology is forming how young people think, communicate, and understand themselves. Whether using generative AI to complete homework, turning to YouTube for answers, or spending hours on apps or in online communities, students are being shaped by what they see, what they share, what they use, and what they consume.

This is why digital and AI literacy are essential to their growth and formation. Students need the knowledge and skills to understand the technologies they use, including their power, their limits, and their effects on human life. Yet literacy alone is not enough. Without moral and spiritual formation, students risk being disciplined by culture instead of Christ. They will be shaped by the values of the marketplace rather than the values of the Gospel.

Catholic schools, families, and parishes have a profound opportunity here: to step into this formative space and help students develop not only the skills to use technology, but also the wisdom to discern its purpose, its impact, and its place in a faithful life. With guidance and support, students can learn that they are

not simply users of technology but children of God, called to live responsibly, creatively, and joyfully in a digital age.

Helping students grow in this way requires more than good intentions. It requires shared language, structure, and direction. In recent years, public frameworks for digital and AI literacy, such as, those from *AI4K12*, *TeachAI*, and *AIEDU*, have emerged to provide exactly that: valuable guidance for schools, policymakers, and communities. These efforts offer a common foundation for understanding what artificial intelligence is, how it works, and how students can use it responsibly. They address the what and how of technology use.

For Catholic education, however, this is only the beginning. Public frameworks often define ethics through fairness, safety, and accountability. These are important goals, but they are incomplete. Rarely do they speak to the deeper theological truth of the human person's dignity.

Responsible use cannot end with compliance or caution. It must draw upon the moral and spiritual wisdom at the heart of the Church. We must also work to answer the questions, "Why," "For Whom," and "Toward What Purpose." As we teach students to navigate an ever-changing world, our work must remain rooted in faith and responsive to the realities of the day.

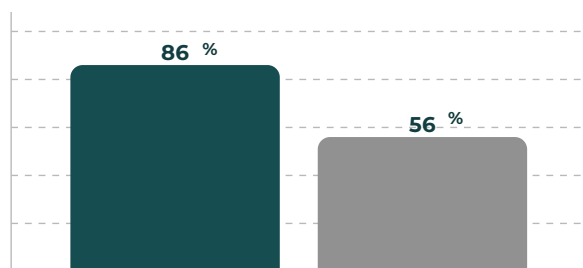


Call for Guidance

When social media first redefined how young people connected, adults were slow to respond. We wrote policies but not pathways, focused on safety instead of formation. As a result, students learned to navigate digital life without guidance, shaped more by the culture around them than by conscience or faith.

The rapid acceleration of AI now offers a second chance to respond differently. Students are already using AI to study, create, and problem-solve with or without adults guiding them. In *Inside Higher Ed's 2025 Student Voice Survey*, 85% of college students reported using AI for coursework, while more than half said it both helps and hinders their critical thinking. Globally, 86% of students use AI regularly, according to the *Digital Education Council (2024)*, yet 58% say they lack the knowledge to use it well.

Students Are Using AI More Than They Understand It

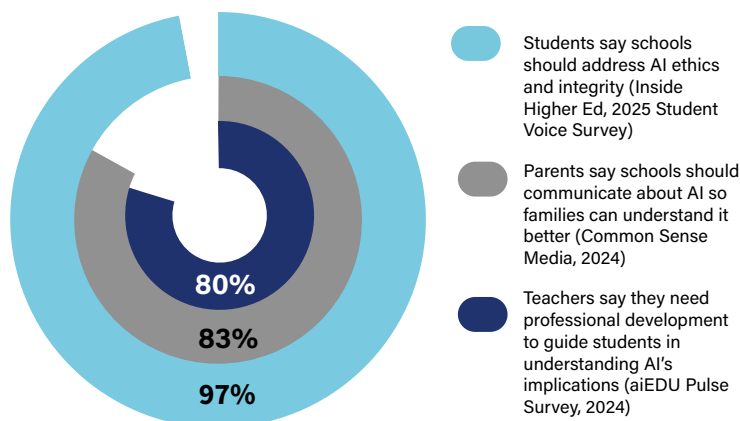


■ Use AI regularly
■ Say they lack the knowledge to use it well

Digital Education Council, 2024 Global AI Student Survey

At home, *Common Sense Media (2024)* found that 7 in 10 teens are using AI, many without teacher permission, while 83% of parents say their schools have never communicated about it, leaving families unsure how to guide conversations and support their children. Teachers feel that same uncertainty. In the *aiEDU Pulse Survey (2024)*, a majority of educators said they see AI's potential to reduce workload and improve efficiency, yet 80% say they still need professional development to help students

Students, Parents, and Teachers are asking for Direction & Support



understand its ethical and societal implications. Three out of four teachers also believe AI guidance should be integrated into lesson plans so students can learn to use it responsibly and reflectively.

75% of teachers think AI guidance should be integrated into lesson plans

Across every study, one theme echoes: students, parents, and educators are asking for guidance. They are not just seeking policies or safeguards, they are seeking support and formation. They want to understand how AI will shape minds, moral life, relationships, and the future.

Policies may govern behavior, but only formation can cultivate wisdom. In the age of AI, we must help students use these tools well and wisely. Catholic education is uniquely positioned to respond. Our mission has never been merely to teach skills but to form persons and we can turn to the foundations of our faith for guidance.

Theological Foundation

Public frameworks can teach digital and AI literacy, but Catholic education must go deeper. The world does not only need students who can use technology well. It needs people who can discern its meaning and moral direction. To do so, we must be rooted in something stronger than the pace of innovation and pressures of society. We must turn to the wisdom of our faith, which has guided humanity through every age of change.

The Church has long reflected on questions of progress, science, and human creativity. From the dignity of work to the care of creation, Catholic teaching provides a unified vision of human life that honors both the gift of reason and the call to holiness.

We can look to the Catechism of the Catholic Church, which affirms that every person is created in God's image and endowed with reason, freedom, and moral responsibility. We can turn to Catholic Social Teaching, which for over a century has illuminated how faith engages the modern world through principles like human dignity, solidarity, subsidiarity, and the common good. We can also draw from the Catholic Anthology of Thought and Wisdom and the reflections of theologians, saints, and scholars who have contemplated what it means to create and participate in God's ongoing work.

And we can find inspiration in the Papal Reflections on Innovation that have guided the Church through every new era of change. Pope Leo XIII's *Rerum Novarum* (1891) called for justice and dignity during the Industrial Revolution. St. John Paul II's *Laborem Exercens* (1981) reminded the world that technology must always serve the human person. Pope Francis's *Laudato Si'* (2015) and *Antiqua et Nova* (2025)

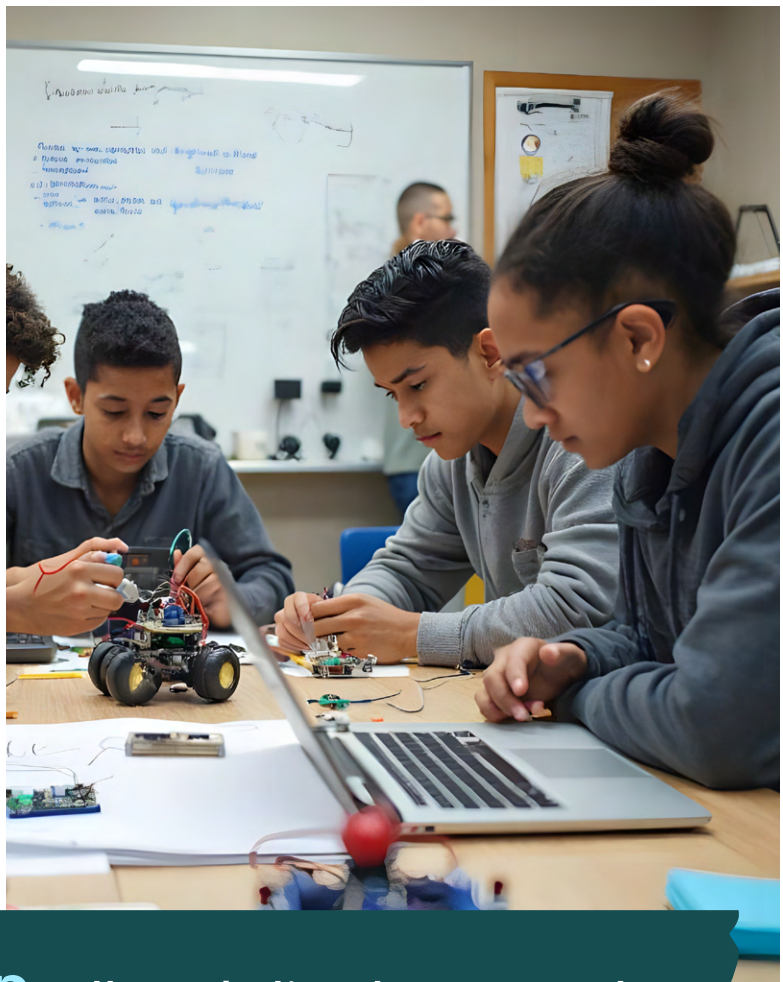


confront the modern “technocratic paradigm,” urging humanity to use innovation for communion, care, and the common good. Documents such as *Gaudium et Spes* (1965) and *Christi vivit* (2019) remind us that the Church's role is not to fear progress, but to guide it and our youth to ensure that the tools of human ingenuity remain in service of truth and love.

These sources form a living tradition, an inheritance of faith, that gives us both language and wisdom for our time. Yet most educators, parents, and catechists are not theologians. Between teaching, meetings, and family life, few have the time to trace these threads through encyclicals and Church documents or to translate them into the classroom or their home.

That is precisely why this framework exists. The Catholic Companion Framework for Technology and Innovation was created to walk alongside you in this work, to serve as a companion that helps you begin, reflect, and root your efforts in the wisdom of the Church.

This framework does not replace the Church's teaching; it celebrates it. It was written to support educators, families, and parishes in forming students as **digital disciples**, integrating faith and discernment into every encounter with technology so that innovation always serves the human person and the common good.



Digital discipleship calls Catholic educators and families to form young people who see digital spaces not only as places to participate safely, but as places to follow Christ faithfully.

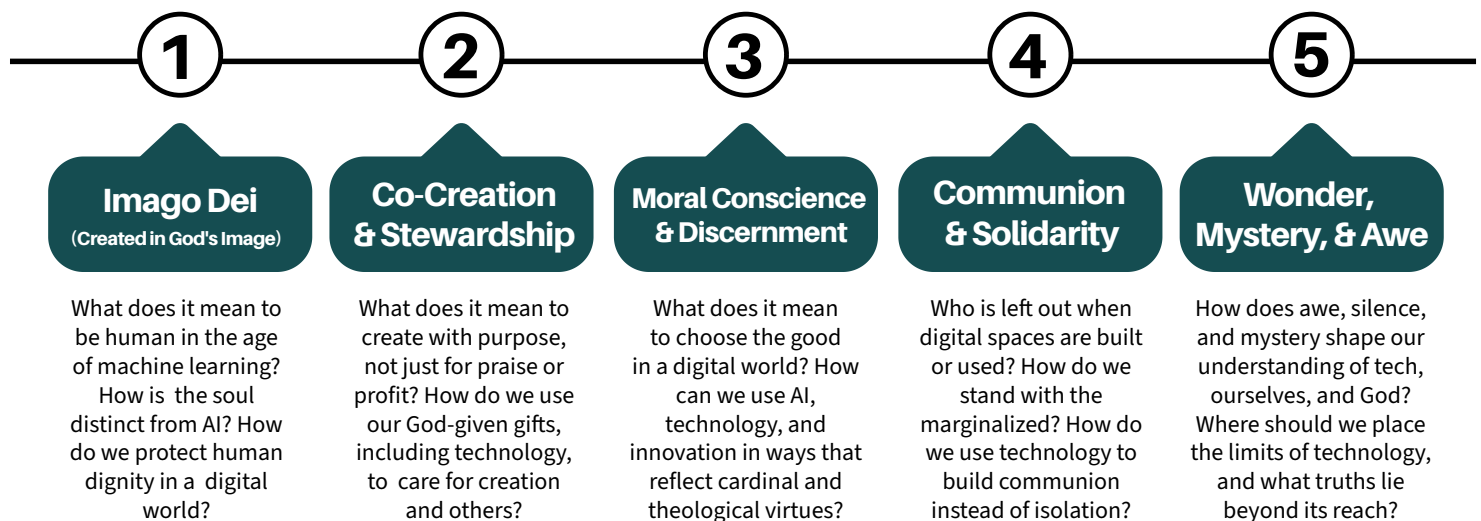


Without faith, students are disciplined by the digital world itself.

Framework's Anchor Strands

At the heart of the Catholic Companion Framework are five key strands. Each strand names a central truth of Catholic teaching and applies it to the evolving landscape of technology, AI, and innovation. Together, they form a coherent vision of digital discipleship, one that integrates technical skills with moral conscience, creativity with responsibility, and knowledge with wisdom.

The strands are not designed to stand alone. **They weave together, much like the threads of a fabric, to give Catholic schools, families, and parishes a sturdy foundation for navigating digital life.** *Imago Dei* grounds the framework in human dignity. *Co-Creation & Stewardship* reminds us of our responsibility to use innovation for the common good. *Moral Conscience & Discernment* shapes the daily choices students make online. *Communion & Solidarity* calls them to use technology to build community and justice. *Wonder, Mystery & Awe* keeps alive the sense that not all truth can be measured, coded, or automated. Woven together, the strands remind us that progress and innovation is not only about what technology can make possible, but what love, wisdom, and justice say it should.



Each strand then expands into five smaller substrands that guide development across grade levels, uniting principles of Catholic moral theology with the competencies outlined in modern AI literacy frameworks. This developmental progression reflects the truth that formation is not a one-time event but a lifelong journey. What begins as a young child learning to treat others kindly in digital spaces matures into a college student discerning how their vocation can place technology at the service of humanity.

For educators, the strands serve as guiding principles, shaping lesson design, classroom reflection, and schoolwide vision. For families and parishes, they provide a shared language for guiding children's digital lives at home and in community. For students, they create a pathway of growth that equips them not only with digital competence but with the virtues and habits of discipleship.

Together, these strands form a vision of digital discipleship that is both deeply Catholic and urgently relevant. They offer a framework that accompanies learners through every stage of growth, ensuring that formation evolves alongside both the student and the changing landscape of technology.

Imago Dei (Created in God's Image)

In a world where machines can simulate creativity, conversation, and even emotion, students are invited to ask what makes humanity sacred. *Imago Dei* anchors that question in the truth that each person bears the image of God and is capable of reason, love, and relationship in ways no technology, however advanced, can imitate. This strand guides students to see dignity as a gift, not achievement, and to measure value not by efficiency but by the divine spark within every human life.



Co-Creation & Stewardship

Students are surrounded by tools that promise endless creation, from apps and code to machines that can build almost anything at the click of a button. *Co-Creation & Stewardship* teaches them that to create is also to care. This strand grounds innovation in reverence for the Creator and for creation itself, reminding students that their digital designs touch both human lives and the earth that sustains them. To co-create with God is to shape technology that serves the common good and protects the world entrusted to our care.



Moral Conscience & Discernment

Students navigate a digital world filled with constant decisions about what to share, create, and consume. Algorithms shape attention and influence choices, often blurring the line between what is easy and what is right. *Moral Conscience & Discernment* forms students to pause and weigh their actions in light of truth, justice, and love. Grounded in virtue and guided by faith, they learn that conscience is not a feeling or a rule but a relationship with God that calls them to act with integrity in every digital space.



Communion & Solidarity

Digital spaces shape how young people relate to one another. Social media can foster connection, but it can also create envy, exclusion, and division. Online platforms can amplify marginalized voices, or they can silence and erase them. AI systems have the power to broaden access or to deepen inequities through bias. *Community and Solidarity* helps students see that their digital lives are not just personal but communal, and that every click, post, or design decision can strengthen or weaken the body of Christ.



Wonder, Mystery, and Awe

In a world of constant noise and instant answers, students rarely experience the quiet that gives rise to wonder. The *Wonder, Mystery & Awe* strand invites them to slow down, to notice beauty, and to recognize that truth cannot always be measured or explained. This strand nurtures humility before God and reverence for the unknown, helping students see that wisdom is found not in control but in contemplation. Through awe and attentiveness, they learn to approach both faith and technology with gratitude and grace.



From Vision to Practice



The five strands of the Catholic Companion Framework offer a vision for digital discipleship, grounded in theology and faith. However, a vision becomes truly transformative when it is lived out in daily practice. This is where the framework's substrands and instructional goals play a vital role.

The substrands and instructional goals translate the strands into concrete expectations across grade spans, from "Before Kindergarten" through "Higher Education". They name what students should come to understand, reflect on, and practice as they grow. In doing so, they create a developmental pathway that ensures formation keeps pace both with students' maturity and with the rapid changes of technology itself.

It is important to recognize that these goals are not meant to be extra content added on top of an already full curriculum. Instead, they are designed to integrate into the life of Catholic education and formation as it already exists. Teachers can draw on them when shaping units and lessons. Families can use them as conversation starters at home. Parishes can adapt them to enrich

retreats, support sacramental preparation, or guide discussion or activities in youth ministry. In every setting, they act as a compass, helping educators and parents open space for conversation and reflection while guiding students to connect their digital lives with their call to live as disciples.

Crucially, the goals are also tool-agnostic. They are not written for a specific platform, device, or AI application. Because tools change quickly, anchoring the framework to current technologies would leave it outdated as soon as the next innovation arrives. Instead, the goals focus on enduring Catholic principles that can guide Catholic communities, regardless of the technologies students encounter.

These instructional goals serve three purposes...

1

Clarity... In a world where technology evolves faster than policies or lesson plans, it is easy for formation to feel scattered or reactive. The standards give teachers, administrators, families, and parishes a shared understanding of what students should know and be able to practice at each stage of development.

2

Consistency... Catholic schools and parishes may look very different from one another, but they share the same mission. By grounding technology formation in theologically rooted goals, communities can align their efforts so that students encounter the same core values and reflections whether they are in the classroom, at home, or in parish life.

3

Discernment... The goals are not intended as technical benchmarks or rigid standards to be met, but as invitations to ongoing reflection. They serve as touchstones that help educators consider how each choice in teaching and technology shapes the formation of their students. In this way, the goals function as living guides, offering direction without prescription, and supporting Catholic communities as they discern faithful and confident paths into a future shaped by technology.

Pedagogical Grounding

In addition to its theological grounding, the Catholic Companion Framework aligns with leading educational research and practice. Its progression follows a clear developmental arc, beginning with simple habits in the early years and growing toward deeper reflection, discernment, and leadership.

In doing so, it mirrors the structure of widely adopted standards such as the *Common Core State Standards* (CCSS) and *Next Gen Science Standards* (NGSS). Functioning as clear, developmental benchmarks that describe what students should know and do at each stage, the instructional goals allow for seamless integration into unit design, lesson planning, and assessment.

The framework also aligns with technology-focused initiatives. The *ISTE Standards for Students* (2016) outline broad, future-ready competencies such as empowered learning, knowledge construction, and digital citizenship. Recent AI literacy frameworks build on this by introducing explicit, grade-level progressions for understanding and using AI.

Together, these emphasize digital literacy, ethics, and critical thinking. The Catholic Companion Framework

extends this work by grounding these same skills in a Catholic vision of human dignity and moral discernment.

Informed by Education Research and Best Practices for Student Learning

It also reflects major approaches to teaching and learning. Drawing on *Understanding by Design* (UbD), each strand offers guiding questions and enduring understandings that center meaning and identity, extending beyond technical skill alone.

Its inquiry-based learning structure invites students to explore essential questions such as, "What does it mean to be human in a digital age?" cultivating curiosity, critical thinking, and a desire for truth and wisdom.

Research on growth mindset and collaborative learning also informs the framework. Many goals emphasize reflection, perseverance, and learning from mistakes and the mistakes of others, showing that virtue and wisdom develop through practice. The

Communion & Solidarity strand calls students to learn with and for others, echoing cooperative learning and social constructivist research by framing technology as a tool for authentic connection rather than isolation.

Finally, the framework integrates insights from social-emotional learning (SEL), connecting to key competencies such as self-awareness, empathy, responsible decision-making, and relationship skills. It helps students recognize how their digital choices shape both who they are and the communities they belong to.



By drawing on these important pedagogical foundations, this Framework reflects how Catholic education and contemporary research point toward the same vision of human growth. It weaves inquiry, reflection, resilience, and collaboration together with a Catholic understanding of dignity, discipleship, and faith, forming students to live with wisdom, courage, and hope in a digital age.



Imago Dei

(Created in God's Image)

- What does it mean to be human in the age of machine learning?
- How is the soul distinct from Artificial Intelligence?
- How do we protect human dignity in a digital world?

The Imago Dei strand invites students to explore what it means to be human in an age of machine learning, reflecting on how our embodiment, relationships, creativity, and freedom reveal a dignity no technology can replicate. It begins with an awareness of being loved and uniquely created by God, then deepens into understanding that every person, including oneself, bears God's image and is capable of love, reason, and moral choice. As students mature, they learn to distinguish human freedom and conscience from artificial abilities. In adolescence, they confront digital and cultural pressures that reduce identity to performance or image, learning instead to value the sacredness of each person, online and offline. By higher education, they engage philosophical and theological inquiry to defend human uniqueness and apply Catholic anthropology to discern how innovation shapes dignity, embodiment, and vocation in a digital world.

		Before K	K-2	3-5	6-8	9-12	Higher Ed
A	Loved & Created by God	Begin to understand that they are special and loved by God.	Recognize that every person is created in the image and likeness of God.	Explain that every person is made in the image and likeness of God, with a body, mind, and soul.	Articulate what it means to be made in the image and likeness of God and how that differs from artificial intelligence or machine learning.	Critically examine philosophical and theological views of what it means to be human and contrast these with technological definitions of intelligence.	Analyze Catholic theological and philosophical understandings of the human person in contrast to secular or technological definitions of intelligence and autonomy.
B	Human vs. Machine	Learn that people are different from toys, robots, screens, and machines because people have feelings and can love.	Begin to understand that people are made in God's image and are different from machines because we can think, choose, and love.	Distinguish between human abilities and artificial intelligence, acknowledging that AI is only a tool and cannot feel, love, or decide what is right and wrong the way a person can.	Reflect on how machines can mimic certain human abilities but lack the body, soul, freedom, and capacity for love that reveal our creation in God's image.	Engage in thoughtful discussion about transhumanism, embodiment, personhood, and machine autonomy through the lens of Catholic anthropology, recognizing that human beings are uniquely different from machines because we are created in God's image.	Apply Catholic teaching to evaluate how emerging technologies affect human identity, agency, embodiment, and the sacramental meaning of human embodiment in light of Church teaching.
C	Respect for Human Dignity	Practice gentle touch with others and kind words because every person deserves respect.	Treat classmates and others with respect because of their God-given dignity.	Treat others with respect online and offline because of their God-given dignity, recognizing that technology can magnify our words and actions.	Respect the dignity of others in all digital interactions, even when algorithms or online platforms make it easier to ignore or attack those with differing opinions.	Evaluate how digital culture, media, and communication practices can uphold or undermine the dignity of the human person, and respond with choices that reflect respect for the body, mind, and soul.	Confront structural and cultural patterns in digital spaces, workplaces, and industries that undermine the dignity of the human person, and work to uphold human life and flourishing, including practices of reconciliation and healing when dignity has been harmed.
D	Ethical Reflection on Technology	Notice and name differences in others (e.g., appearance, ability) and learn that these differences are part of God's creation.	Learn that every person is valuable, no matter their differences, and practice protecting privacy as a way to show respect for yourself and others.	Understand that even people who are different or marginalized have equal value in God's eyes, and begin to recognize that protecting personal information and respecting others' privacy online is part of honoring dignity.	Recognize how technology and online systems can shape perceptions, treat people with differences unfairly, or fail to respect personal privacy and dignity.	Analyze how technologies (e.g., AI, biometrics, social scoring) may challenge or erode the understanding of human dignity, including how violations of cybersecurity and privacy can harm freedom and identity.	Contribute to dialogue about personhood, embodiment, and AI through the lens of Catholic anthropology, evaluating how technology upholds dignity, the common good, and creation's sacramental meaning.
E	Advocacy & Witness	Understand that everyone is loved by God and show God's love by caring for yourself and others in your family, school, and community.	Remember that everyone is loved by God, and demonstrate this by using kind words and treating others with respect both when using and not using digital devices.	Recognize the unique dignity of every person, and demonstrate this by telling the truth, helping others, and making choices that honor people over popularity or "likes," both online and offline.	Analyze ways technology can either support or diminish the dignity of the human person (e.g., social media pressures, digital identity, automation replacing work), and explore how they can respond in ways that uphold dignity.	Discuss cultural narratives and ways technology reduces people to data or productivity, and advocate for practices that protect dignity and freedom, including restorative actions that rebuild trust and community when harm occurs.	Challenge narratives that reduce humans to data, productivity, or algorithmic value, and actively advocate for policies and practices that safeguard human dignity in technology and innovation.



Co-creation & Stewardship

- What does it mean to create with purpose, not just for praise or profit?
- How do we use our God-given gifts, including technology, to care for creation and others?

The Co-Creation and Stewardship strand helps students see their creativity and curiosity as reflections of God's creative nature. In early years, they delight in making and sharing good things, discovering that their abilities are gifts meant to bring joy to others. As they grow, they learn that technology and innovation can serve or harm creation, depending on how they are used. Students practice habits of balance and responsibility in their digital lives while exploring how their talents and tech skills can contribute to the good of the community. By higher education, they discern how vocation, innovation, and stewardship intersect, using their gifts to advance justice, sustainability, and human flourishing in God's ongoing creation.

		Before K	K-2	3-5	6-8	9-12	Higher Ed
A	Gifts & Talents for Service	Recognize their abilities as gifts that can be used to create and bring joy to others.	Celebrate their imagination and creativity as a gift from God that can help others in their class or family.	Discover their strengths and talents, including ways they use technology, and explain how these can serve others at school or in the parish community.	Explore how personal talents and tech skills (e.g., coding, media, design) can serve others and the mission of the Church.	Examine how their gifts and emerging skills in science, technology, arts, or design can shape their vocational choices and serve both the Church and the wider world, discerning how innovation and career paths can reflect a call to co-create responsibly.	Discern how the application of one's unique gifts and vocation, including skills in STEM, education, design, or communication, can be used to serve the common good, advancing ethical innovation and faithful leadership in professional life.
B	Stewardship of Tech Use	Begin to put digital devices (e.g., watching videos, playing games) away when asked in order to share time with others.	Notice when using digital devices too much can take away from family, friends, and play, and practice simple habits of stewardship like sharing or turning them off when needed.	Identify their digital habits (e.g., screen time, gaming, online videos) and explain how these choices affect attention, relationships, and ability to care for others and the world.	Discuss how patterns of tech use (e.g., constant notifications, multitasking, overuse) may influence their ability to focus, learn, and maintain healthy relationships, and begin to suggest strategies for balance.	Assess how their own digital practices, including screen time, multitasking, and consumption, support or undermine stewardship, and evaluate how emerging technologies invite responsible design and governance.	Critically examine how habits of tech use (e.g., multitasking, device addiction, productivity obsession) affect one's ability to steward time, relationships, and creation, applying moral discernment to innovation and systems that shape human and environmental well-being.
C	Celebrating Creation & Innovation	Observe the good things people make (e.g., buildings, art, tools, digital toys) and celebrate them as part of God's creation, finding joy and play in creating and sharing.	Discover that creating new things like stories, art, or simple digital projects can show God's love and help others.	Explore inventions or technologies that help people or care for creation, and explain how they reflect God's call to do what is good and loving.	Analyze how innovations in science, media, or technology can be used for good or harm.	Evaluate examples of innovation in contemporary culture, reflecting on whether they participate in God's ongoing act of creation by serving what is good, true, and loving.	Integrate theological reflection to discern how innovation contributes to God's ongoing creation when ordered toward truth, love, and justice.
D	Justice & the Common Good	Practice sharing technology (e.g., toys, tablets, tools) and using them kindly with others.	Recognize that digital tools should be used responsibly and fairly, showing respect for others, for God's world, and for the earth.	Highlight ways technology can help or harm different people and the environment.	Examine how technology affects access to and use of the world's resources, particularly for vulnerable communities, and reflect on how it can be guided by justice and responsibility.	Analyze technologies through the lens of Catholic Social Teaching (CST), asking if they advance sustainability, care for the environment, equity, and human dignity or reinforce consumerism and inequality, considering global supply chains and environmental impact.	Apply principles of Catholic Social Teaching (CST) to evaluate and design technology systems that promote sustainability, environmental stewardship, equity, and human flourishing, integrating global solidarity into ethical innovation.
E	Creative Contribution & Collaboration	Create joyful works (e.g., drawings, block structures, digital art) and share them with others.	Use art, stories, or simple digital tools to create purposeful works that help, thank, or bring joy to others.	Design simple creative projects (e.g., posters, videos, presentations) that serve, teach, or encourage their community.	Collaborate on technology projects that respond to real needs in their school or community, showing stewardship and care for others.	Design and evaluate projects that promote stewardship, justice, and the dignity of the human person in both local and global contexts.	Develop professional or academic solutions (e.g., lesson plans, apps, programs) that embody stewardship, foster collaboration, and advance the Gospel mission.

Moral Conscience & Discernment

- What does it mean to choose the good in a digital world?
- How can we use Artificial Intelligence and technology in ways that reflect cardinal and theological virtues?

The Moral Conscience and Discernment strand forms students to think, choose, and act with integrity in both digital and daily life. It begins with learning that choices have consequences and that truth and kindness matter, even when no one is watching. As they mature, students learn to pause, reflect, and seek wisdom before acting, understanding that conscience is shaped by faith, reason, and community. They learn to examine their intentions, weigh the moral impact of their digital actions, and recognize how technology can influence judgment. They practice virtue and self-reflection, learning to align their choices with love, truth, and justice. By higher education, they engage in theological and ethical reflection to lead with moral and intellectual agency, ensuring that technology serves human reason rather than replaces it.

		Before K	K-2	3-5	6-8	9-12	Higher Ed
A	Choices and Consequences	Recognize that choices have consequences, both helpful and hurtful.	Practice telling the difference between helpful and hurtful choices when using technology.	Determine the benefits and consequences of using digital tools in different ways.	Consider how intentions, actions, and consequences work together in morally evaluating the use of digital tools.	Identify where laws and ethics diverge, and discuss their responsibility to act with integrity beyond compliance and the external pressures of society or culture.	Uphold moral integrity in institutional and systemic uses of technology by acting beyond external expectations or compliance, shaping decisions that safeguard human dignity and the common good.
B	Kindness & Truth in Tech Use	Practice honesty and kindness by following simple rules when using materials or technology (e.g., take turns, use gentle hands, ask for help when unsure).	Begin to make truthful and respectful choices (e.g., speak kindly, tell the truth online and offline, care for others' work) when using technology without reminders.	Identify situations where digital tools can be misused (e.g., plagiarism, unkind comments, cheating), and begin learning how to tell when something online is true or misleading.	Discern how digital tools can be used truthfully and responsibly by considering purpose, impact, and reliability, choosing actions that lead to truth and love, recognizing how media and algorithms shape what we see and believe.	Develop habits of self-examination, accountability, and openness to moral truth, especially in digital environments, evaluating digital culture and media influence through moral reasoning, and recognizing misinformation, deepfakes, and biased sources.	Demonstrate a personal or institutional code of digital conduct rooted in Catholic values and a commitment to justice and truth, critiquing cultural narratives and digital systems including discerning reliable information in academic, professional, and public contexts.
C	Examination of Conscience	Name how their actions make others feel.	Explore how our actions, even when using technology, can impact others.	Examine their conscience in the context of their digital actions to determine if it is loving and Christ-like.	Examine their conscience based on Church teaching, not just peer approval or online trends and consider how to repair harm done through digital actions.	Engage in theological reflection (e.g., Ignatian, Augustinian) on whether and how to use specific technologies or platforms, including how mercy and restitution restore relationships when harm occurs.	Apply theological frameworks (e.g., Ignatian, Augustinian) to critically discern the ethical, social, and vocational implications of adopting or designing specific technologies or platforms, seeking reconciliation and renewal where technology has caused division or harm.
D	Virtue & Moral Reasoning	Look to Jesus as the example of love, forgiveness, and truth when making choices.	Recognize why it is important to make loving and truthful choices like Jesus, and practice doing so each day, even when no one is watching.	Explore the virtues of prudence, justice, fortitude, and temperance as guides for making loving and truthful choices, especially when using technology.	Explore how cultural messages about convenience, speed, and profit influence digital choices, and begin discerning how the virtues of prudence, justice, fortitude, and temperance guide a more loving and truthful response.	Explore real-world ethical technology dilemmas (e.g., data privacy, academic integrity, digital authorship, environmental impact, AI surveillance) using virtue ethics, natural law, and Church teachings.	Employ Catholic moral reasoning, grounded in natural law and virtue ethics, to evaluate complex moral issues in emerging technologies (e.g., AI, robotics, biotechnology), discerning actions that uphold truth, justice, and human dignity.
E	Human Intellect & Moral Agency	Begin to understand that God made their mind to help them think and make good choices.	Explain that God made their mind to choose what's right and wrong, and that digital and nondigital tools can support their thinking but should not decide for them.	Discuss how technology can help or harm their own thinking, and commit to honoring their God-given mind by keeping their judgment active.	Exercise emerging agency by choosing when to rely on their own reasoning rather than defaulting to digital tools, recognizing that technology can support learning but cannot replace human judgment.	Strengthen moral and intellectual agency by making deliberate choices about technology's role, ensuring it supports rather than directs their thinking and decisions.	Lead with moral and intellectual agency in academic, professional, and civic life by integrating Catholic moral reasoning with prudent use of technology, ensuring human thinking and judgment is never replaced by machines.



Communion & Solidarity

- Who is left out when digital spaces are built or used?
- How do we stand with the marginalized?
- How do we use technology to build communion instead of isolation?

The Communion and Solidarity strand helps students understand that we are created for relationship with God, one another, and the wider world. It begins with learning to share, include, and care for others, both in person and through technology. As students grow, they see how digital habits and design choices shape belonging and justice, discovering that true community cannot be reduced to followers, likes, or visibility. They learn to use technology to build empathy, amplify marginalized voices, and serve the common good. By higher education, they model authentic presence and solidarity across cultures and digital spaces, using their gifts to form communities rooted in dignity, compassion, and the love of Christ.

		Before K	K-2	3-5	6-8	9-12	Higher Ed
A	Community & Belonging	Play, share, and learn together as a community. (e.g., taking turns, helping others, noticing when someone needs support).	Practice sharing digital tools, helping classmates, and using technology in ways that build friendship and teamwork.	Show empathy and kindness when using technology with others by listening, encouraging, and repairing harm when it happens.	Explore how digital habits and design choices shape relationships, inclusion, and togetherness.	Discern the difference between genuine community and shallow or performative belonging, and collaborate with others to build communities marked by justice, solidarity, and true connection.	Lead efforts that transform digital communities into spaces of justice, solidarity, and communion, modeling a culture of belonging for the wider world.
B	Justice & Access	Acknowledge that not everyone has the same toys or devices	Begin to see that it's fair to share technology and care for others who have less.	Understand that unequal access to technology creates real differences in learning and opportunity.	Investigate how technology can exclude people, both by design (e.g., bias, inaccessibility, language) and by access (e.g., devices, internet, affordability), and connect these patterns to global inequalities.	Evaluate how digital and AI systems promote or hinder justice, equity, and the dignity of every person, and reflect on how all people share responsibility for building a more just digital world, considering global inequities and environmental costs linked to technology production and use.	Contribute to solutions that address the social, cultural, and economic impact of technological innovation on marginalized populations (e.g., bias, accessibility, automation), advancing justice and human dignity, integrating global solidarity and environmental responsibility into design and policy.
C	Presence & Togetherness	Notice how screens can sometimes interrupt togetherness, and begin experiencing face-to-face play, joy, and comfort as gifts from God.	Discuss how screens can sometimes distract or isolate us, and explore how digital tools like videos, photos, or class projects can also bring us together.	Begin to determine whether digital actions bring people together or leave others out and choose responses that strengthen togetherness.	Practice using technology to amplify marginalized voices and promote empathy, collaboration, and shared mission.	Examine how technology can isolate, divide, or suppress marginalized voices (e.g., echo chambers, deplatforming).	Examine how digital technologies shape belonging and exclusion, and help design practices or policies that strengthen justice, empathy, and true communion.
D	The Common Good	Begin to see how Jesus teaches us to be kind and include everyone, and practice this in simple ways with classmates and technology.	Share stories of Jesus building community, and connect His example to how we include and care for others, including when using technology.	Learn about saints and other role models who served the vulnerable and consider how technology can be used for good today.	Examine principles of Catholic Social Teaching (solidarity, subsidiarity, dignity of the person) in relation to digital tools and platforms, including how algorithms and online spaces can isolate or divide communities.	Apply Catholic Social Teaching to assess technology issues (e.g., bias, surveillance, inequitable access, echo chambers), and practice dialogue across differences as a way of resisting polarization and building peace for the common good.	Shape scholarship, design, and dialogue that form others to use technology for the common good, modeling justice, solidarity, and peace rooted in Catholic Social Teaching, and fostering collaboration across nations and cultures.
E	Service and Evangelization	Participate in simple acts of love and care (e.g., praying together, helping a friend) that show Jesus' love for others.	Begin expressing Jesus' love with others through prayer, song, or simple digital messages that tell others about God's goodness.	Use technology to bring faith and care to your local community (e.g., sharing prayers, gratitude projects, or digital messages of hope).	Discuss how the Holy Spirit leads the Church to share the Gospel worldwide, and use technology to connect with others in prayer, learning, and service.	Model Gospel values through digital action and dialogue, advocating for truth, justice, and unity while respecting others' dignity and beliefs.	Champion digital evangelization and service efforts that shape culture toward communion, guided by the Holy Spirit and rooted in humility, truth, and solidarity, engaging in dialogue with people of other faiths and worldviews to promote shared ethical principles in digital life.

Wonder, Mystery, & Awe

- How does awe, silence, and mystery shape our understanding of technology, ourselves, and God?
- Where should we place the limits of technology, and what truths lie beyond its reach?

The Wonder, Mystery, and Awe strand helps students see that faith and curiosity work together to reveal God’s truth in a world shaped by science and technology. It begins with awe and joy in creation, growing into gratitude for discovery and the human capacity to innovate. As students mature, they learn that while technology can reveal the beauty of creation and expand human understanding, it also has limits and some truths belong to mystery and cannot be engineered or controlled. They practice habits of reflection, silence, and prayer that keep curiosity grounded in humility. By higher education, they learn to approach innovation with reverence, integrating faith and reason to ensure that human creativity remains ordered toward wisdom, virtue, and wonder before the Creator.

		Before K	K-2	3-5	6-8	9-12	Higher Ed
A	Wonder at Creation	Find awe and joy in nature, animals, people, and name these as part of God’s creation.	Express wonder at God’s creation, especially things no computer can understand (love, prayer, miracles).	Notice how science helps us learn about God’s creation, while remembering that some truths remain a mystery of faith.	Discuss how wonder can lead to discovery in science and also to deeper spiritual awareness of God’s creation.	Reflect on how scientific exploration can reveal the order and beauty of God’s creation and call us to reverence and care.	Engage in dialogue between science, theology, and technology, integrating knowledge and faith to contemplate creation’s ultimate meaning.
B	Mystery Beyond Technology	Ask big questions about the world around them and begin to hear that some answers come from God.	Recognize that some things (like how God loves us) are mysteries, not problems to be solved.	Acknowledge that some questions (e.g., “Why does God love us?”) are beyond science and technology’s reach.	Understand that technology itself isn’t good or bad but rather how we use it shapes its impact.	Examine the limits of human control and the temptation to “perfect” humanity through technology.	Reflect critically on how technological determinism can diminish reverence for mystery, and recognize divine providence as greater than human mastery.
C	Faith and Science in Harmony	Hear that science helps us learn about the world God made.	Ask questions about how the world works and learn that science and faith both reveal God’s truth in different ways.	Understand that curiosity and discovery are gifts from God and that science helps us care for creation.	Explore how faith and science work together to seek truth, and how both require humility and respect for creation.	Discuss how scientific progress and innovation must be guided by moral values and human dignity, understanding that not everything possible is good.	Integrate faith and reason in academic or professional study, recognizing that true knowledge serves the human person and reflects God’s creative wisdom.
D	Wisdom & Responsibility	Begin to see that technology can be helpful, but people are needed to love, laugh, and glorify God.	Notice that some things are better done with people than with devices, like sharing, playing, or comforting a friend.	Recognize when digital tools help and when they distract or replace real understanding or kindness.	Demonstrate prudence when deciding how to use technology wisely, understanding that wisdom means knowing limits.	Use prudence to evaluate when technology serves or harms truth, justice, and human dignity, and choose restraint when its use conflicts with the good of others or creation.	Apply prudence and moral reasoning to guide innovation, research, and design, ensuring that technological progress remains ordered to virtue, human dignity, and the common good.
E	Prayer, Silence, & Contemplation	Enjoy quiet, stillness, and prayer, learning that good gifts come from God and not only from screens or toys.	Participate in short moments of prayer and quiet during the day, learning that we can talk to God anywhere, even when using technology.	Practice building habits of gratitude and prayer in daily life, including when using technology.	Practice setting boundaries around screen time and tech use in order to preserve space for prayer, silence, and real-world connection.	Recognize how overuse of technology can dull the interior life, and commit to concrete practices that restore stillness, attention, and persevering prayer, including moments of digital fasting that renew focus and peace.	Cultivate spiritual practices (e.g., silence, examen, lectio divina) that foster interior freedom and protect against over-reliance on productivity or digital stimulation, fasting from technology as a form of contemplative resistance.

In Service of the Community

Formation is not confined to a single age or setting. It spans the entirety of learning and life. For this reason, the framework provides grade-banded instructional goals that reflect the developmental journey of students, while remaining flexible enough to guide those who walk with them at every stage.

Though its instructional goals are most directly applied in classrooms, the Catholic Companion Framework is not limited to teachers. It is designed to support all who play a formative role in the lives of young people: school leaders, parents, families, and faith formation or ministry leaders. Each brings a unique perspective, yet all share the same mission: helping children and adolescents grow as children of God and digital disciples in a world shaped by technology and innovation.

Educators

As technology and artificial intelligence continue to reshape education, many teachers are searching for ways to respond. The Catholic Companion Framework helps educators integrate digital formation into what they already teach, offering language, structure, and direction rather than adding new content or programs. In doing so, it gives educators the confidence to guide digital formation without needing to be technology experts.

Organized around five strands, the framework helps teachers connect technology to purpose. For instance, Co-Creation & Stewardship can frame a science lesson on caring for creation, while Moral Conscience & Discernment can guide reflection on the creative integrity of AI use. By focusing on formation rather than tools, the framework empowers teachers to meet students where they are and help them grow in wisdom, responsibility, and faith.

Leaders

For Catholic school leaders, the challenge is not just keeping up with technological change, but leading it with mission and meaning. Each new innovation brings both opportunity and responsibility, calling for discernment rooted in faith. The Catholic Companion Framework grounds decision-making in faith rather than efficiency or outside pressure. Its strands offer a shared language for how technology serves formation, and its grade-banded goals provide clear benchmarks for student growth.

From this foundation, administrators can cast a mission-centered vision for digital discipleship, evaluate tools, policies, and programs through Catholic values, and form faculty around shared goals rooted in faith and learning. The result is confident, coherent choices that strengthen Catholic identity and genuinely serve student formation.

Parents & Families

Parents are the first educators of their children, forming both faith and character. In a world shaped by smartphones, social media, and AI, that calling can feel overwhelming. The Catholic Companion Framework offers reassurance and a shared language for families and schools to walk together in forming digital disciples.

While originally designed to complement classroom use, its five strands easily extend into home life, giving parents a simple way to connect faith with daily digital experiences. Imago Dei reminds children that every online interaction involves a person made in God's image. Co-Creation & Stewardship invites balance and responsibility with devices. Mystery, Wonder, and Awe encourages prayer, reflection, and quiet in a noisy world. Together, these anchors help families see digital life as part of their child's ongoing call to discipleship.

Ministry Leaders

Digital formation extends beyond the classroom. The Catholic Companion Framework supports pastors, catechists, and youth ministers in helping young people connect their online lives with their faith. Its strands provide a shared language for reflection and conversation, guiding students to see digital choices as part of their discipleship.

For example, Communion & Solidarity can shape discussions about empathy, inclusion, and authentic online community, while Wonder, Mystery, and Awe invites youth to step back from screens for prayer and silence. By echoing the same principles taught in schools, parishes and ministries create a consistent message of faith across a young person's life, helping them integrate technology into a life rooted in relationship with God and others.

Walking Forward Together

The Catholic Companion Framework is not a policy manual or checklist. It is a companion, one that walks beside Catholic schools, parishes, and families as they discern how to support students and live faithfully in a digital world. Companions do not rush ahead with all the answers or linger behind in critique. They journey alongside, attentive to the path, the questions, and the people they accompany.

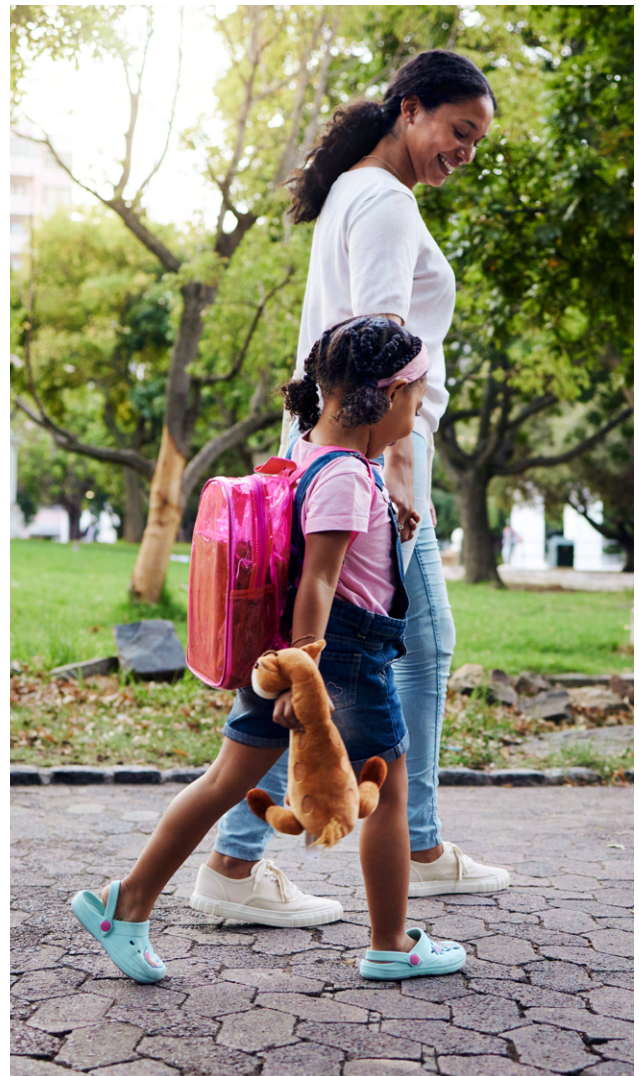
Because technology continues to reshape how we learn, communicate, and create, the road ahead can feel uncertain. The framework does not promise every answer, but it seeks to support the way, to offer guiding questions, developmental goals, and wisdom drawn from Scripture, Catholic Social Teaching, and the lived experience of educators and families. Its purpose is not to prescribe but to prompt reflection and discernment, reminding each community that they do not walk this path alone.

This first edition was written with both confidence and humility: grounded in the enduring wisdom of the Church, informed by sound pedagogy, and attentive to the realities of our digital age. It was created to last, offering principles that remain steady even as technologies shift. When renewal is needed, future updates will grow naturally from the experiences of those who bring it to life not from the pace of innovation, but from the fruits of formation.

The framework finds its fullest meaning when it is lived, when teachers weave its goals into learning, when leaders use it to shape vision and policy, and when families bring its language into their homes. Each encounter becomes a moment of formation, where faith meets innovation and discipleship takes root in the ordinary choices of daily life.

We move forward in communion, teachers and administrators, parents and pastors, catechists and ministers, each sharing in the mission of forming wise, faithful, and hopeful disciples in a world shaped by technology.

Though the terrain may shift and the tools may change, our purpose remains the same: to help every young person know themselves as a beloved child of God, called to create, discern, and lead with love. May this framework serve as a steady companion on that journey, keeping us anchored in the Gospel, strengthened by one another, and attentive to the future God is unfolding before us.



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Meaghan is an educator, curriculum designer, and professional learning developer whose work sits at the intersection of Catholic tradition, innovation, and academic excellence. She helps school and educational communities integrate technology with purpose, align innovation to mission, and design learning experiences that reflect human dignity and deepen student engagement. Her research and writing explore how Catholic education can approach emerging technologies with wisdom, discernment, and hope. Learn more about her work and upcoming resources or trainings related to this framework at meaghancrowleysullivan.org.

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